

The Function of the Myth in Plato's Philosophy

Author(s): Ludwig Edelstein

Source: *Journal of the History of Ideas*, Oct., 1949, Vol. 10, No. 4 (Oct., 1949), pp. 463-481

Published by: University of Pennsylvania Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2707185>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



University of Pennsylvania Press is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Journal of the History of Ideas*

JSTOR

THE FUNCTION OF THE MYTH IN
PLATO'S PHILOSOPHY*

BY LUDWIG EDELSTEIN

Every reader of Plato's works, even the casual reader, must be aware of the fact that this master of subtle logical disputation is also an adept of myth. To be sure, dialectics for Plato always remains the central topic of philosophy. The early dialogues, with the exception of the *Protagoras*, do not contain any mythical tale at all. In the later writings—the *Phaedo*, the *Gorgias*, the *Symposium*, the *Republic*, the *Timaeus*, the *Politicus*—they are introduced on rare occasions and with specific motivations. Nevertheless, at least starting with the middle period of Plato's literary activity, these wondrous stories seem to occupy a fixed and allotted place within the cosmos of his philosophy. And on their embellishment he has bestowed no less exertion, no less diligence than on the elaboration of definitions and divisions. The unfathomable profoundness of the dialectician is equalled if not surpassed by the captivating grace of the story teller. Nowhere, perhaps, does Plato show as clearly as in the recounting of a myth that to him indeed "speech is more plastic than wax and other such media" (*Republic* IX, 588 D). Listening to his tales, one is spell-bound, one is bewitched as it were, one believes in the reality of worlds which no mortal eye has ever seen or will ever penetrate.

Yet is it not precisely the artistic charm, the appeal to the emotional, that disqualify the myth from being used by the philosopher? Are mythology and philosophy not enemies, the one seeking pleasant fancies, the other seeking stern truth? Hegel, speaking of Plato's myths, claims that such stories are appropriate only for the childhood of mankind; when reason has grown up and has matured, they become obsolete. The ancient rationalists did not judge differently. To them, Plato's fondness for mythology was but additional proof that he was willing to revert to old superstitions; for long before Plato, Greek philosophers had discarded the myth as unworthy of him who searches for

* This and the following article were read before the Johns Hopkins Philological Association in 1947.

knowledge. To counter such charges, the Neo-Platonists of antiquity and of later centuries insisted that the Platonic tales were meant to be taken allegorically, that a truly philosophical significance was hidden in them.

On the other hand, it has been maintained by many interpreters of Plato's works, modern and ancient alike, that he attributed to the myth a validity of its own. He was aware, it has been claimed, of the limitations of reason; about certain problems, the soul and the cosmos, one can discourse only in pictures of imagination. Those who are themselves Kantians see in the Platonic myth an instrument by which transcendental feeling is roused and regulated. Man is likely to transgress the limits set to his understanding; the myth directs the licentiousness of human reason into proper channels. The Romanticists go even further. According to them, Plato was not only conscious of the limits of rational thought, he also knew that in mythical fantasy, in inspiration which the philosopher shares with the poet, man experiences the revelation of a higher truth, of the suprarational or the divine. It is in a soberer mood that philosophers, historians and philologists motivated by modern pragmatism or existentialism consider the myth a device by which Plato intended to call men to action or to express in words that part of his being which defies the rigidity of conceptual knowledge.

Divergent as these interpretations are, all of them acknowledge one fact: the question of the significance of the Platonic myth is linked up with the problem of the relationship between reason and imagination, between philosophy and poetry. Plato himself spoke of a controversy between the philosopher and the poet in regard to mythology. Even to him, the quarrel between the two was one of old standing (*Republic* X, 607 B), nor did the fight cease in the following generations, each of which turned to Plato in agreement or disagreement with his views. Both these aspects of the issue, the philosophical and the aesthetic, I have in mind when I attempt once more to determine what instigated Plato's interest in the myth. In my investigation I shall pay attention not so much to the modern theories—only from time to time shall I pause to consider them—as I shall try to follow Plato's lead, even Plato's words, in order to characterize his position in his own terms. And since his myth is not an entirely artificial creation but is set

against the background of common Greek mythology and determined by it, I shall begin by analyzing Plato's attitude toward the current beliefs.

In Plato's time, mythology was still a living power. It was the traditional religion of the Greeks, their "theology" as Plato says (*Republic* II, 379 A), that had been fashioned mainly by Homer and Hesiod. It dealt with gods and daemons and heroes, with the world's coming into being and the future life in Hades (*Republic* III, 392 A). As the accepted religion of the day it pervaded the whole existence of the people. To this popular mythology, Plato like many an earlier philosopher or poet, was bitterly opposed, for in his opinion it was impious and full of error. Not even in education was he willing to give it its traditional place. Discussing the training of the guardian of his ideal state, he considers for a moment whether it would be possible to retain the ancient saga, that is, the old kind of poetry, and to purge it of its objectionable features by submitting it to allegorical interpretation. But he decides that the young would be unable to distinguish between what is and what is not allegory (*Republic* II, 378 D). Mythology, he concludes, ought to be reformed altogether.

Plato did not feel it incumbent upon himself to compose this new kind of mythological stories. He only lays down the patterns after which they should be written (*Republic* II, 379 A ff.). Philosophy proves that God is good, that he never deceives. Consequently, every myth that tells of gods who cheat men or cheat each other, has to be discarded. Likewise, tales, according to which the gods fall prey to emotions, will be deleted. For the deity is free of passions; envy has no place among the gods. The entire vocabulary of terror and fear is to be expunged from the description of Hades. Death is nothing to be feared. The myth, thus, must be made to conform to the results of philosophy. Such stories alone are to be told to the child as reflect the truth of dialectics.

This, in brief, is Plato's program for a new mythology that may be used in education. And thus far one should expect the philosopher Plato to go. At best one would anticipate that he might allegorize the myth for philosophical purposes; for the philosopher, to be sure, must be capable of distinguishing between what is and what is not allegory. Plato occasionally plays with

the allegorical interpretation, a means by which philosophers and rhapsodists of his day were wont to reconcile the thought of previous centuries with the findings of progressing knowledge. Thus he mentions Homer together with those who hold "that all things are the offspring of flow and motion," since the myth of the marriage of Oceanus and Tethys (*Iliad* XIV, 201; 302) apparently is meant to express such a philosophical explanation of the universe (*Theaetetus* 152 E). But when Socrates is asked in plain language whether he believes in the truth of fables, he declines even to take them as allegories. Allegorical interpretation of the myth, in his opinion, is "a rustic kind of wisdom" that leads nowhere; it can hardly ever be brought to completion (*Phaedrus* 229 B-230 A).

Instead, Plato creates a mythology of his own. That in doing so he draws heavily on the common mythology is obvious. The framework, the basic symbols, the main figures of the Platonic myths have their counterpart in the old familiar sagas, and those who recount the tales, be they Socrates or any other of the interlocutors, usually give their report on the authority of other people. It is equally obvious that Plato composes his philosophical myth in accordance with that insight which he has gained through dialectical analysis. The myth to him is a story shaped at will. As such it is not the antithesis to reason. Introducing one of his descriptions of the nether world, Socrates can say to his partner in the dialogue (*Gorgias* 523 A): you will regard my account as a fable (*mythos*), I regard it as a reasonable story (*logos*). The myth, in his hands, is truly an instrument of the human intellect. Nevertheless, the myth is not presented with the certainty that inheres in dialectical knowledge. Of a myth one can only be persuaded. It would be unfitting for a man of sense to maintain that things actually are as the myth describes them; this is at most likely or probable (*Phaedo* 114 D). The myth, "taken as a whole, is false, but there is truth in it also," affirms Socrates of the fables of the poets (*Republic* II, 377 A). The same is valid of the Platonic myth. And yet, the philosopher must venture to believe in it; he will gladly listen to these tales (*Phaedo* 114 D; *Timaeus* 29 D). Without the addition of a myth, some of the philosophical investigations would certainly not reach their goal (*Republic* X, 614 A).

Why is this so? Why is philosophy in need of mythology which, as Plato admits, does not convey pure truth even if truth is contained therein? These questions can be answered only by an evaluation of the philosophical myths themselves. But before I venture to scrutinize them it is appropriate, I think, to emphasize two results that can already be established. Whoever takes the Platonic myth as allegory is hardly right. Ancient and modern Neo-Platonists are refuted by Plato's own words. He refused to apply allegorical interpretation to the myths of others; he certainly did not wish to have this "rustic kind of wisdom" applied to his own mythology. But whoever finds in the Platonic myths the revelation of a higher knowledge is not right either. Reason to Plato is supreme; myth is subservient to reason. For him, the myth has nothing solemn or mysterious, as the Romanticists are prone to imagine. Plato's philosophical fable is the fable of the philosopher.

Now there are two groups of stories in the dialogues that in Platonic terminology can be classified as myths: those dealing with an account of the creation of the world and with an account of the early history of mankind, and those that deal with the fate of the soul before and after this life and have a bearing not on metaphysics or science but rather on ethics. The *Timaeus*, the *Critias* and parts of the *Politicus* provide the tales concerned with an understanding of the world in which man lives and of his past; the *Phaedo*, the *Gorgias*, the *Phaedrus* and the *Republic* provide those concerned with the destiny of man in the world above the heavens from which he comes and to which he may return.

The presuppositions of the first group of these myths are clearly set forth by Plato. Human reason can grasp only that which always is and never changes; it can grasp only the eternal forms or ideas. Concepts, that is, express the universal, and thus contain truth and certainty, though by their very nature they are unable to give any information of the individual, of that which changes and becomes. If one wishes to speak of change and becoming, as it is characteristic of the history of the world, one can do so only by relating a story, a myth, the consecutive parts of which reflect and imitate change. And since the links in this story, themselves belonging to change and becoming, are not to be grasped by reason either, still less by experiment, such stories

remain guesswork. They will be neither self-consistent nor exact (*Timaeus* 29 C-D). The occurrences of early history, of "antiquity," likewise are beyond human knowledge; in regard to them too one can supply only imagined probabilities instead of ascertained facts (*Republic* II, 382 D). The investigation of the beginnings of history is mythology (*Critias* 110 A).

But what then is true, what is false in these stories? It seems as if such tales about nature and history could not have any truth whatever. Such an assumption, or conclusion, would be erroneous. If one constructs nature in such a way that the story shows how God created the world so as to make it as perfect as possible; if one constructs history in such a way that the story shows how God is present in history, how the various periods of the development of mankind were nearer to God or farther removed from Him—under this condition and to this extent is the account truthful. For time and temporal events came into being so that they might be as like to the patterns of eternal nature as possible (*Timaeus* 38 B-C). If taken as a symbol of eternity, the world is understood correctly. An accurate historical account is the transposition of an ideal drawing,—outlined as it were in a fable,—into the realm of fact (*Timaeus* 26 B; cf. *Republic* II, 382 D). On the other hand, the manner in which the eternal is embedded in natural phenomena and human deeds, can only be surmised by man. Certainly, one account may be more likely than another, yet to give the most likely account is all that human nature permits (*Timaeus* 29 C-D; cf. *Republic* II, 382 D). The details with which the story is embellished, in the last analysis, remain uncertain. Plato would not stake his reputation on the theory that divine providence stationed the liver in the lower region of the body so that this organ, being the seat of the vegetative soul, will not disturb the divine intellect residing in the head (*Timaeus* 70 D ff.). Nor would he be willing to wager his good name on the claim that in the Golden Age all men used to discourse all day long with one another and with the animals (*Politicus* 272 B-C). The "facts" of nature and of history, which ancient and modern commentators have tried to sift out of the myths of the *Timaeus* and the *Critias* and the *Politicus*, these "facts," however likely, remain guesswork. Certain is only this much, that God, looking up

to ideas, created the cosmos, that there was divine guidance of mankind in the past and that some day it will be restored.

Yet, if this is so, if no more certainty can be obtained, must one not ask why these elaborate stories are told at all? Can the philosopher not do without them? He really does not gain more from listening to them, or from composing them, than he might express in one sentence, namely that the world is the work of God's handi-craft and that His providence pervades human history. As for the rest, opinions, even those that approximate truth, are not truth, and to philosophize, Plato teaches, means to aim at knowing rather than at opining. To be sure, it is inherent in the nature of human understanding that truth and falsehood are forever closely interwoven. Altogether free from falsehood, altogether simple and true in word and deed, are the divine and the daemonic alone (*Republic* II, 382 E). But then one should think that the philosopher should try to become like God not only in his deeds so far as this is possible for him (*Theaetetus* 176 B), but also in his words; at least he should refrain from uttering falsehood. He should show his responsibility and his judgment by not going further than his knowledge will carry him. With such considerations or objections Plato, it seems, is nowhere concerned. In passing he mentions that the historical tale may serve for the clarification of logical difficulties (*Politicus* 274 E); the cosmological myth "beginning with the origin of the cosmos and ending with the generation of mankind," allows the historian to take over mankind "already, as it were, created by speech" (*Timaeus* 27 A). But even where Plato refers to the usefulness of the historical myth, it is a usefulness that at the same time offers some amusement (*Politicus* 268 D). The search for the history of old and mythology "are visitants that come to the city in company with leisure" (*Critias* 110 A). And of cosmology Plato simply states: "Whenever for the sake of recreation a man lays aside arguments concerning eternal realities and considers probable accounts of becoming, gaining thereby a pleasure not to be repented of, he provides for his life a pastime that is both moderate and sensible" (*Timaeus* 59 C-D).

The myths concerning nature and history, then, are a pastime, an amusement, a playful game (*paidia*), a recreation from arguments concerning ideas, a means by which to while away our leisure

(*scholē*). To understand the full impact of these words, one would have to be able to penetrate the deepest depths of Platonic philosophy. To outline briefly what the terms seem to imply, I hazard only with diffidence. Nothing in this world, Plato teaches, exists without its opposite (*Phaedo* 60 B). Pleasure is inextricably connected with pain, pain with pleasure. In ethics, the hedonistic calculus, therefore, will never work out. Evil can never be done away with; for there must always be something opposed to the good (*Theaetetus* 176 A). It is impossible to strive for the one without accepting the other. In the same way, seriousness would defeat its own purpose if it were not willing to admit playfulness. Thus the philosopher knows that one can teach philosophy only by discussing its problems with the individual, by delivering the thoughts which reside in the pupil's soul, and it is this living dialogue with others that is the serious task of the philosopher. Nevertheless, he will put down his views, and "plant the garden of letters." Doing this is a pastime, an amusement in which he passes his leisure as others pass it, refreshing themselves with banquets and kindred entertainments (*Phaedrus* 276 D-E). Moreover, there can be perfection even in playfulness. Just as the works of the philosopher which he composes for his own amusement, the written dialogues, are composed with infinite care, encompassing a cosmos of men and arguments, endeavoring to capture the best, the most convincing *logos*, so the myths are composed with infinite care, selecting the best, embodying all findings of men, so as to make the tale the most likely account. Finally, to play may indeed be an imitation of the divine. Is it not difficult to say whether men, the ingenuous puppets of the gods, were contrived as playthings of theirs, or rather for some serious purposes (*Laws* I, 644 C)? And should man not live playing at peaceful pastimes, —the really serious business of life,—sacrificing, singing, dancing, so that he be able to win heaven's favor (*Laws* VII, 803 E)? Certainly one partakes of immortality by serious philosophizing, by "thinking thoughts that are immortal and divine" (*Timaeus* 90 B-C). Yet stories dealing with the world and with mankind are also admirably suited for celebrating the deity. It is at the festival of Athena that the myths of the *Timaeus* and the *Critias* are recited (*Timaeus* 26 E). Thus, the terms seriousness and playfulness are imbued with the peculiar ambiguity of Platonic irony, and

in the twilight of this realm only this much remains certain: they are the two aspects of the one indissoluble unity of human and maybe even of divine life.

Whether or not I have succeeded in suggesting the implications of Plato's thought, and even though its final significance may remain inscrutable, one must accept Plato's verdict that the cosmological and historical myth is a play, an entertaining story that is likely, though by no means entirely trustworthy. I need hardly stress the fact that by taking such an attitude toward the problems of natural science and history, Plato was utterly at variance with the great natural philosophers and critical historians of the fifth and fourth centuries B.C. The former,—and among them Democritus was perhaps the foremost—had propounded a rational analysis of nature; experience had been given its share in this undertaking. Thucydides had separated history from mythology; even prehistory, to him, was a realm to be penetrated by critical conjectures based on factual evidence. Plato, one might say, sided with the metaphysician Parmenides and with Herodotus, who admitted the myth into the field of history. Plato holds indeed that human reason is limited. The important point is that he finds the limitations of reason where ancient rationalism, as well as modern rationalism, detects the strength of reason if allied with experience: in the detailed understanding of the phenomena of nature and of history. On the other hand, Plato takes it for granted that reason is capable of proving the principles of an interpretation of both natural and historical facts. What Kant introduces as an hypothesis, the teleology of nature and of history, as an "as if" in his famous phrase, Plato holds to be beyond doubt. It seems to me that those who interpret Plato in categories of Kant are inclined to overlook, or to minimize, this fundamental difference between the two. And yet, it is precisely this disagreement that speaks against their attempt to define the Platonic myth as a means of rousing and regulating transcendental feeling. That which to Kant is transcendental feeling or licentiousness of reason, to Plato is the very task of reason, and mythical fantasy or feeling holds sway where Kant's rational causality reigns supreme. Again, since it is the world and history that withstand the rigidity of conceptual thinking, it would hardly do to restrict the use of the myth to questions concerning the cosmos and the soul, nor would

it be sufficient to say that the myth expresses the inner existence of man or appeals to his practical nature. Though the historical tale according to the educational theory of the *Republic* (II, 382 D; cf. *Politicus* 274 E) is of practical value, the philosophical myth, the imaginative picture of the perishable, is an intellectual amusement.

Yet it is time to leave these discriminations aside and to turn to the second group of myths which I have to consider, those that deal with the fate of the soul before and after this life, those that is which have a bearing on ethics. In regard to them Plato's pre-suppositions are not expressed as clearly as they are in regard to the first group of myths; still, they can be comprehended with a fair degree of assurance. In his ethical research the philosopher is able to establish with certainty the rules of conduct; it can be proved that to suffer injustice is better than to do injustice. Socrates succeeds even in establishing the immortality of the soul, at least to his own satisfaction and to that of his friends. He has never met anybody who, trying to defend amorality, could not be refuted (*Gorgias* 527 A–B); he is convinced that no argument can be brought against his thesis that the soul is immortal which he would not be capable of countering or of showing to be erroneous. In ethics, then, the case stands differently than in natural science and history: human reason is able to cope with its task, it provides knowledge. To be sure, Plato is willing to admit that the dialectical argument may run into difficulties; objections may be raised, nor is it easy to distinguish between good and bad arguments. But on that account one ought not to despair of the intellect; the disappointment should not make a man a hater of reason, a misologist; it should not cajole him into adherence to mere belief, or into scepticism, or worst of all, into acquiescence. One must blame one's own lack of skill, one must go on investigating, and in the end the right argument will emerge victorious (*Phaedo* 89 B ff.). And yet after having proved the rules of right conduct, the immortality of man, Socrates adds a myth, depicting the life of the soul in Hades (*Gorgias* 523 A ff.), or picturing the rewards and punishments that await the soul in the Beyond (*Phaedo* 107 B ff.). Otherwise, he says, the argument would not be complete (*Republic* X, 614 A).

The ethical myth, then, is an addition to rational knowledge; it does not take the place of rational knowledge, as do the historical and scientific myths. It is a superfluity of riches, as it were. On the other hand, it is true, the ethical myth, too, transcends knowledge. That the souls are born many times, that from Hades they rise in the ninth year to the upper sun (*Meno* 81 B–D), that there is a heaven where at the banquets of the gods divine intelligence feasts on ideas and where the horses of the deities are given ambrosia and nectar (*Phaedrus* 247 A–E)—how unlike the banquets of the Homeric gods!—all such things of course cannot be really affirmed or established with certainty. And even if the most elaborate results of contemporaneous learning are integrated into a story (*Phaedo* 108 E ff.), as is perhaps Democritean science into the cosmological myth, the details remain guesswork. The picture of the cosmos, of the earth changes; the representations of Hades in the *Gorgias* and in the *Phaedo* are not identical, and the historical myths of the *Politicus* and the *Critias* agree with each other just as little. Here fantasy holds sway. It would not be fitting for a man of sense to assert that all this is exactly as it has been described (*Phaedo* 114 D). What is certain is again but the pattern of construction: that there is life after death and previous to life.

But why should it be necessary to resort to surmise that cannot stand the test of logical criticism? Is not the ethical myth even more superfluous than the cosmological and historical tales, since ethical knowledge is self-sufficient? In addition, reward in this world or in the Hereafter should not influence the actions of the righteous. He must follow the moral law whatever the consequences. Plato is aware of this objection. He proves that justice itself is best, even if stripped of all rewards that may be bestowed upon it by men or gods, whether it possesses the ring of Gyges or the helmet of Hades to boot (*Republic* X, 612 B; cf. II, 367 D–E). Nevertheless, having ended the inquiry “which indeed is no easy one but calls for keen vision” (*ibid.* II, 368 C), he grants to the just not only all the rewards that virtue brings men among men but also those which it receives from the gods (*ibid.* X, 612 D). His reason is that “the tale was saved as the saying is, and was not lost, and it will save us if we believe it” (*ibid.* X, 621 B–C). If the philosopher ventures to believe that the gods are not indifferent

to the fate of men, neither here nor there, he will find the venture worth while, for he will be of good cheer, he will gain courage (*Phaedo* 114 D). He will exert all his strength in acquiring virtue and wisdom in life, “for the prize is fair and the hope great” (*ibid.* 114 C); he will endure in the moral contest of life that is worth all other contests on this earth (*Gorgias* 526 E). In other words, the ethical myth speaks to man’s passions; it rouses and confirms hopes; it enhances courage and allays fears. It is like a charm that one must sing to oneself (*Phaedo* 114 D). And since the song is directed toward the emotional part of the soul, since it is meant to have a psychological effect—if I may use this phrase—it gains in power, if it is repeated and drawn out (*ibid.* 114 D). Man’s reason may be convinced by an argument that is given once; fear and hope take time in being moulded aright, they need ceaseless training.

Whereas the cosmological and the historical myths are a pastime of the intellect, the ethical myth is rooted in man’s irrational nature, and it cannot be banished from philosophy because both these parts of the human soul must be equally tended by the philosopher. Inasmuch as man thinks, “inasmuch as he is for ever tending his divine part and duly magnifying that daemon who dwells along with him, he must be supremely blessed. But the way of tendance of every part by every man is one—namely, to supply each with its own congenial food and motion” (*Timaeus* 90 C). Nor is it merely a question of giving to each part its own deserved due for the sake of fairness and justice. Pleasure and fear can influence the intellect; they bewitch reason and destroy insight. Just as men have their opinions stolen from them by time which “strips them unawares of their beliefs,” or by arguments that overpower them with their seeming strength, just as men change their minds compelled by some physical pain or suffering, so they alter their views “under the spell of pleasure or terrified by some fear” (*Republic* III, 413 A–C). Pleasure and fear therefore may at any moment put the intellect to shame unless they are properly guided. Moreover, in addition to the two foolish and antagonistic counsellors whom everybody possesses within himself, Plato says at the end of his life, calling them by the name of pleasure and pain, everybody possesses opinions about the future, “which go by the general name of ‘expectations’; and of these, that

which precedes pain bears the special name of 'fear,' and that which precedes pleasure the special name of 'confidence' '' (*Laws* I, 644 C). Whatever man knows, whatever he grasps by reason, whatever he decides about right and wrong, he also anticipates his coming fate, he fears and hopes for his future in this world no less than in the other, and he will persevere in the truth which philosophy teaches only if his hopes and fears are in accordance with his knowledge. That is why one must counteract sorcery by sorcery (cp. *Republic* III, 413 C with *Phaedo* 114 D).

In the beginning of my discussion I have drawn attention to the fact that the myth, important as it is for Plato, does not have a place in all his dialogues, that in fact it comes to play its rôle in his later works alone. Perhaps I can now explain this circumstance and in doing so summarize my results and clarify them to some extent. The scientific and historical myths are propounded above all in the *Timaeus* and in the *Critias*, which were certainly written after the *Republic*. In the latter work the ideas or forms are for the first time clearly viewed as the source of the existence of things as well as of their essence, that is, of their being in the full meaning of the term. Thereby the problem was raised how the creation of the world of phenomena, of nature and of history, should be understood in detail, provided that the idea of the good is the cause of all existence. The *Timaeus* and the *Critias* undertake to give the answer. On the other hand, the ethical myth is found in the *Gorgias*, the *Phaedo*, the *Phaedrus*, the *Republic*. In the *Gorgias* Plato hints at his conviction that man's reason is not omnipotent (525 B-C). While in his early dialogues he gave the impression that to know the good means to be able to do the good, he now begins to acknowledge that in man's soul there are powers capable of thwarting the decisions of reason. The *Phaedo* speaks of the conflict between man's soul and his passions (94 D-E). The *Phaedrus* and the *Republic* develop the dogma of the tripartite soul in which reason holds but a precarious supremacy. Justice, the highest virtue, now is that attitude of man which makes the parts of his soul function in their native way. Reason is to lead; the passions are to be led, and they are to be controlled mainly by habituation. The ethical myth could indeed hardly be introduced in any dialogue that antedates the *Gorgias*. (The *Protagoras* which I have mentioned as the only exception from the rule, really is not

an exception; for the myth told there, even though it may be tinged by Platonic concepts, is a more or less historical reproduction of the views of Protagoras).

Proposing such an explanation I do not wish to identify myself with those theories which suggest a development of Plato's philosophy. Even if Plato has established the ideas as the causes of existence for the first time in the *Republic*, even if he has brought out the importance of the irrational factor for the first time in the *Gorgias*, his thought may have proceeded along similar lines long before. His written work, the earlier dialogues, centered on different subjects. Besides, even in his latest work, the *Laws*, Plato insists on the dogma that virtue is knowledge, and tries to reconcile this theory with his insight into the independence of passions; he does not entirely discard his ethical rationalism. Whether Plato's turning to mythology resulted from a change of heart, or whether it was the natural outgrowth of convictions that he always cherished, the significant fact remains that he dared to integrate, or re-integrate, the myth into philosophy. By this venture he succeeded in reconciling the irrational and the rational aspects of human nature. It is the saving grace of Plato's intellectualism that it can do justice to the emotions without infringing upon the prerogatives of reason, which to be sure is man's most precious possession, for it is divine. Just as the intellect is allowed, nay obliged, to play no less than to obey the strict laws of dialectics, to imagine no less than to define and to divide, so the intellect is enjoined to be intelligent as well as kind and understanding in its relation to that man within man, or to the "child within us" (*Phaedo* 77 E) who fears and hopes and who must be persuaded until his fears are charmed away and a spell of hope has been cast upon him. Plato is not a Stoic for whom passions are but mistaken judgments. The rigid dignity of the wise man, superior to pain and pleasure because he has made himself insensible to passions, is as foreign to Plato as is the stern pathos of doing one's duty in the course of human affairs, of the business of the day. On the other hand, Plato's rationalism is a far cry from that of the Kantian. God and immortality, to Plato, are not transcendental objects, postulates of practical reason but never to be grasped by theoretical reason. He knows that God exists, that man is immortal. He can indulge in metaphysical dreams with a good con-

science; these reveries are a permissible, nay a necessary, pastime of the intellect. Moreover, Plato is willing to hope for reward, to believe in eudaemonia, in the eudaemonia of the righteous in thought and deed, for in this hope, in this belief, he feels more certain of his moral existence. But never does he acknowledge a truth that reason cannot grasp, that lies beyond its reach, because reason is "fragmentary." The myth, shaped in accordance with reason, brings to the realm of the passions the light of the intellect; it instigates man to act with hope and confidence toward the goal which reason has set before him. Through the myth the inner core of man's existence receives the commands of the intellect in terms that are adequate to its irrational nature. Thus man in his entirety is put under the guidance of philosophy, and Plato has fulfilled the demand which he himself made even upon the student of the world of physical phenomena: "in all things to seek after the divine for the sake of gaining a life of blessedness, so far as our nature admits thereof, and to seek the necessary for the sake of the divine, reckoning that without the former it is impossible to discern by themselves alone the divine objects after which we strive, or to apprehend them or in any way partake thereof" (*Timaeus* 68 E-69 A).

Mythology, then, is an intrinsic part of Platonic philosophy. It is for good reasons that it has its place within the cosmos of Plato's thought. It was not Plato's reactionary temper, it was not anti-rationalism that caused him to revert to the myth. This much I trust to have shown through my brief analysis of the subject. In bare outlines I hope to have made clear the indispensable function of the myth within the framework of subtle dialectics. Supposing that the main points of my discussion are correct, it would still be necessary to work out the details of my thesis. For that purpose one would have to consider not only the most important mythical tales but even those which Plato tells in passing, such as the fables referred to in the *Phaedrus* (274 C ff.), or in the *Meno* (81 A ff.). In addition, one would have to connect the study of the myths with that of the several dialogues in which they appear and then again to relate the use of mythology to the specific philosophical problems which Plato tries to unravel in his various works. All this I cannot do here. But if I wish not to be remiss even in answering those questions which I myself have raised here,

I must go at least one step further and show in which way Plato's attitude toward mythology affects his judgment on poetry.

That it is the task of the poet to compose myths, Plato himself acknowledges (*Republic* II, 378 E), and one might therefore claim that the myths which he has woven into his dialogues are the work of the poet Plato. Yet he has deigned to write only such myths as are fit for the accomplished philosopher. As I have pointed out before, he refrained even from composing those stories which were to be used in the education of the future guardians of his ideal state; rather did he restrict himself to laying down the patterns according to which they were to be fashioned (*Republic* II, 379 A ff.). Surely, it was not his intention that his own philosophical myths should be read by children, in a school edition, as it were. Beautiful and poetical as they are, they would be beyond the grasp of the young. They are, moreover, prose compositions, not poetry in the strict sense of the word, and it is poetry, music, that is needed for the education of the soul (*Republic* II, 376 E). Nor would Plato have imagined that on the basis of his philosophical myths religion could be taught to the many. And yet, he was of opinion that for the multitude mythology embodies all that they will ever be able to learn about the divine. Philosophy, he held, is but for the few. Even royal statesmanship guides the people in unison with rhetoric, persuading them "by telling stories" (*Politicus* 304 C). In his *Laws*, therefore, he bases the life of the city not on philosophy—an impossibility in the world of reality with which this dialogue deals—but on mythology. However, it is a reformed mythology and by no means the objectionable old inherited religious legend which he wishes to enthrone. Hermes is not to be the Hermes of the poets or "perverse myth mongers" (*Laws* XII, 941 A–B). The masses are not to be deceived or swayed by mere fiction. What they are deprived of is the philosophical understanding of the truth; they are limited to the imaginative reflections of dialectical knowledge. Unlike the Stoics, or modern Machiavellian statesmen, Plato was not willing to let the people live under the domination of a religion which he himself despised, while he reserved for the philosopher the right to apply his own thought to the common religion, thereby giving it a different meaning. And who other than the poet could be charged with composing the myths needed for the education of the citizens of the "ideal state" or for that of the masses in the "second best state"?

Still, it seems as if Plato had refused forever to poetry a place among the goods to be enjoyed by men. He has driven out of his city, the pattern of which is "laid up in heaven" (*Republic* IX, 595 B), the "honeyed muse in lyric or epic," Homer "the most poetic of poets and the first of tragedians"; no poetry is admitted "save only hymns to the gods and the praises of good men" (*Republic* X, 607 A). But it is the poetry of the past alone and of his own day which he thus condemns almost without exception, even though he is conscious of her spell and seems to hope against hope that her advocates may be able to plead her cause and show "any reason for her existence in a well-governed state." For "reason constrained us" to dismiss her from the state (*ibid.* X, 607 B-C). If poetry is "not only delightful but beneficial to orderly government and all the life of man," if she "bestows not only pleasure but benefit," it will be clear gain to listen to her, she may justly return from her exile (*ibid.* 607 D-E). There is no real quarrel between poetry and philosophy, as long as poetry will bow to censorship (*ibid.* II, 377 C; cf. *Laws* II, 658 E ff.). This censorship is not to be exercised by any chance person, or by the arbitrary decision of aesthetic or philosophical criticism, nor is the usefulness of poetry to be understood in terms of narrow and passing political or moral ideas. The poet, to use a phrase of Goethe's, must take "the veil of poetry from the hands of truth." Just as Plato has refused entrance to the old kind of poetry because "it would be impious to betray what we believe to be the truth" (*Republic* X, 607 C), so he imposes upon poetry the censorship of truth, of true usefulness. She must learn to represent God in His true quality (*Republic* II, 379 A ff.), to picture man not as he may actually live, but as he ought to live in accordance with the destination of his higher nature (*Republic* X, 604 B ff.; cf. *Laws* II, 660 E ff.).

The fact that poetry, if it conforms to such standards, will in some respects be the loser, is fully realized by Plato. He says himself: "The fretful part of us presents many and varied occasions for imitation, while the intelligent and temperate disposition, always remaining approximately the same, is neither easy to imitate nor to be understood when imitated, especially by a non-descript mob assembled in the theater" (*Republic* X, 604 E). Poetry which submits to Plato's ideal is a thing difficult to accomplish; it is in danger of becoming boring; its popular appeal is diminished, and

this, to be sure, holds equally good in regard to the description of man and gods. The myth, as Plato imagines it, cannot compete with the poetical charm or attractiveness of Homer's stories, or with the overpowering greatness of the tragic fate that pervades the tales of Aeschylus or Sophocles. Nevertheless, the task can be achieved by him who believes that truth is the goddess supreme. In subject matter poetry in fact would not differ from Homer's and Hesiod's and Aeschylus' poems, for they too wrote about the heavens and the realm of the dead, about the genesis of the world, about the Golden Age, about gods and men, and Thersites has his place in Homer as well as Achilles. How grandiose an epic that sings of the creation of the world and the judgment in Hades, as the *Gorgias* and *Phaedo* picture them, of the heavens, the gods and the souls in their chariots, as the *Phaedrus* describes them, of the Golden Age, as the *Politicus* visualizes it! How stirring a tragedy the death of Socrates! How comic a figure that mannikin, the philosophical pretender who looks like "a bald-headed tinker, who has made money and just been freed from bonds and had a bath and is wearing a new garment and has got himself up like a bridegroom and is about to marry his master's daughter who has fallen into poverty and abandonment" (*Republic* VI, 495 E)!

The possibility of a new poetry on Plato's terms one can readily conceive, and for such a new poetry that would fulfill his demands, Plato, I think, was hoping. His dialogues gave to the philosopher a new mythology, and in this sense they constituted a new poetry. But he was waiting for poets who would do fresh work, who would replace the prose myth which he had composed by a truly poetical myth embodied in epics and tragedies and comedies as well as in hymns to the gods and in praises of good men. These poets he would have admitted not only to the "second best state," as he actually did, where the polity is framed "as a representation of the fairest and best life, which is in reality, as we assert, the truest tragedy," where men themselves are "the authors of a tragedy at once superlatively fair and good" and thus rivals of the poets "as artists and actors of the fairest drama" (*Laws* VII, 817 A ff.); he would have admitted them even to his "ideal state," in regard to which "it makes no difference whether it exists now or ever will come into being," which is there for him "who wishes to contemplate it and so beholding to constitute himself its citizen" (*Republic* IX, 595 B). To their poetry, even the philosopher

Plato would gladly have listened, for to him, rhythm and harmony more than anything else find their way to the inmost soul and take strongest hold upon it, "bringing with them and imparting grace" if they are rightly chosen (*Republic* III, 401 D). Poetry does not, as Aristotle would have it, free men from passions, but by representing them implants them in man's heart (*ibid.* X, 606 A-B; cf. 605 B). Where could Plato find a stronger ally for that aim which he attributed to the telling of a myth than in poetry, that is, in the right kind of poetry?

The ancient poets did not heed Plato's call. The epic, as far as it dealt with nature and history, became didactic poetry, versified science. The natural phenomena were not viewed as a simile of the eternal; they were interpreted and explained in a rational way. The mechanistic universe which Lucretius celebrates is the antithesis of the world created by the Platonic god. Even the poem of Manilius, though it knows of providence, does not know of the Beyond. History, too, became rationalized. Lucanus, to be sure, is aware of the divine fate that governs human events. But the Fate in which the Stoic believed is not the deity to which the Platonist paid his respect. Vergil's epic comes perhaps closer to Plato's wishes; still, it hardly is all that he was anxious to have. As for tragic poetry, wherever it did not rework the themes of old mythology, or in Roman times, simply translate the classic and Hellenistic Greek drama, it even resorted to the description of contemporary life. The philosophical plays of the Cynics or Stoics were moral exercises; the triumph of man over fear and hope, over fate, was glorified. The comedy reviled the gods in the style of Aristophanes. Man was shown in his most human aspects; fun was poked at him as he lives his daily life, concerned with the petty worries and pleasures of his individual existence.

Ancient poetry did not fulfill the expectations of Plato. Or perhaps I should say it could not fulfill his expectations. Plato was the only one who believed in the cleavage between idea and reality; he was the last one to believe in the truth contained in the myth. After him, the myth became allegory, it was no longer religion; it was merely an embellishment, a poetical adornment. Whether any poet of later ages, living in a world of new beliefs and new hopes, ever rose to the height of Plato's vision of a new poetry, this is not for me to decide.

University of California at Berkeley.